



SARITA DEVI

Former boxing World Champion



BOXERS STIR PARIS **HOPES** WITH PROMISING SHOW

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The year 2023 was very good for the Indian boxers, especially the women. We have qualified in some weights and are yet to qualify in others. For those who have qualified, there must be some areas of improvement in the run-up to the Paris Olympics. Those who aspire to qualify must work harder with the primary focus of booking berths for Paris.

We began the year well by winning four world titles at home. Nikhat Zareen (50kg) has been in very good form, and Lovlina Borgohain (75kg) has also done well. Both have qualified for the Olympics, and the pressure of booking a quota place will not be there for them while preparing for Paris 2024. It is the same for Parveen Hooda (57kg) and Preeti Pawar (54kg).

Apart from rectifying their mistakes, qualified boxers must focus on their fitness, gaining strength, and hitting with more power. With the quality of women boxers we have, I am sure we will do well and can even win an Olympic gold.

The male boxers have performed reasonably well but haven't been as successful as the women. They need to



Clear path: Lovlina Borgohain (75kg) has performed admirably, securing an Olympic qualification and relieving the pressure of earning a quota place in the build-up to Paris 2024. R. V. MOORTHY

put in more effort and strive to earn some quota places. They have won three bronze medals in the World Championships, indicating their potential to qualify for the Olympics. Mohammad Hussamuddin (57kg), with whom I have trained in the past, is a really good and experienced boxer, and if he can recover from his injury in time and get back to form, he is a bright prospect.

When you are injured, you need good support. I remember competing in the 2014 Commonwealth Games with a wrist injury. Thanks to a physio's assistance, I reached the 60kg final. Subsequently, with support from the Olympic Gold Quest, I returned to boxing after undergoing wrist surgery. So, Hussamuddin can also make a comeback. Other boxers, such as Deepak Bhorla (51kg) and Nishant Dev (71kg) can gain confidence from their Worlds

medals while trying to qualify for Paris 2024. Other good boxers can do it too. Both boys and girls need extreme determination to achieve success. With government and corporate support, they should only focus on training and giving their best.

As told to Y.B. Sarangi